

Participant 1 – Mei Lin (F, 24, Mandarin, IELTS 5.5, Intermediate tech user, postgraduate student)

“Every time I join a Zoom discussion, I feel this small rush of panic. I rehearse what I want to say in my head, but then someone else starts speaking, or I mishear something and lose my chance. English isn’t my first language, so by the time I form the sentence, the topic has already shifted. Once, I spoke up, and everyone went quiet—just for a second—but that second felt like judgment. Maybe they didn’t understand me. Maybe I froze. After that, I typed my points in the chat instead, but it doesn’t feel the same. The flow of voice, the timing, the laughter—those things don’t live in text. I’ve learned to keep my mic muted most of the time. It’s safer that way. I listen, I take notes, but I don’t feel like I’m in the room. It’s strange how something designed for communication can make you feel so invisible.”

Participant 2 – Deepak (M, 31, Indian, IELTS 6.5, Advanced tech user, project manager)

“The hardest part about Zoom isn’t the meeting—it’s joining and leaving. When I click ‘Join,’ I never know what I’m stepping into. Sometimes people are mid-laughter or already deep in discussion, and I appear like a glitch on screen. Everyone looks at me for a second, then the conversation awkwardly restarts. Leaving is even worse. You say ‘bye,’ but lag makes it sound like you’re talking over someone. I’ve had so many times when I waved, no one responded, and I sat there smiling too long, unsure if they saw me. Then I’d finally press ‘Leave Meeting’ and feel strangely guilty, like walking out of a conversation mid-sentence. In real life, you can read the rhythm—you pack up your laptop, people wave, there’s closure. Online, everything ends abruptly, like cutting a wire. I sometimes stay a few seconds longer just to make sure the goodbye lands.”

Participant 3 – Aisha (F, 26, Malaysian, IELTS 6.0, Intermediate tech user, postgraduate tutor)

“When I teach on Zoom, I try to bring energy, but it feels one-sided. Most of my students keep their cameras off, and I’m talking to a wall of black boxes with names. When I ask a question, there’s a pause—too long to tell if they’re thinking or if the Wi-Fi dropped. I start filling the silence just to keep things alive. Later, a student told me, ‘We were nodding, miss, just didn’t turn our cameras on.’ That hit me harder than I expected. I realised how much I depend on visual cues—nods, eye contact, small smiles—to feel like I’m reaching someone. Without them, it’s like teaching in a vacuum. I overcompensate, I talk faster, I wave my hands even when no one’s watching. At the end, I close my laptop and just sit there in silence. It’s hard to tell if I’ve connected with anyone.”

Participant 4 – Jorge (M, 33, Portuguese, IELTS 6.5, High tech user, researcher)

“Breakout rooms make me anxious. You click, and suddenly you’re in a new place with strangers already mid-sentence. It’s like teleporting into someone else’s conversation. I usually say, ‘Hi, everyone,’ and they all stop talking, which makes it worse. Sometimes I just keep my mic off for the first minute to get a sense of who’s speaking to who. But even then, it’s hard. You can’t read the room—literally. Once, I entered a breakout room where two people were joking in Spanish, and I didn’t want to interrupt. I waited until they finished laughing, but by then, the timer popped up saying we’d return to the main room. I said maybe five words total. It’s funny, in real life, I’m talkative. On Zoom, I feel like a guest at my own meeting.”

Participant 5 – Aruna (F, 29, Hindi, IELTS 6.0, High tech user, research assistant)

“English is my working language, but it’s not the language I think in. During meetings, I often pause before speaking, just a second to translate in my head. But that second feels like forever online. The silence gets filled by someone else, and the chance is gone. Once, I unmuted just as someone else did. We both said, ‘Sorry, you go ahead,’ and then both stopped again. We laughed, but it was that awkward kind of laugh. After a few times, I just gave up trying to jump in. I noticed native speakers don’t even think—they just talk, and everyone follows. For me, it’s like waiting for traffic to clear before crossing the road. That constant hesitation builds up. By the end of the meeting, I have so much to say but nowhere to put it.”

Participant 6 – Kenji (M, 35, Japanese, IELTS 5.5, Intermediate tech user, PhD student)

“Joining a breakout room always makes me nervous. I never know who will be inside or what they’re already talking about. The names appear first, then the faces, and suddenly everyone’s quiet, looking at me. I say ‘Hi,’ but no one answers right away, maybe because they’re muted. The silence feels heavier online. Sometimes I wish Zoom gave you a preview—like hearing a few seconds before you enter—just so you can prepare. I once joined a room where people were debating intensely. I tried to follow but couldn’t catch up. I kept smiling awkwardly until someone asked, ‘Kenji, do you agree?’ I had no idea what they were talking about. I just said, ‘Yes, I think so,’ and hoped it fit. When the host pulled us back, I exhaled like I’d escaped something.”

Participant 7 – Rini (F, 25, Indonesian, IELTS 5.0, Basic tech user, master’s student)

“I rely on captions a lot because sometimes the accent or audio quality makes it hard to follow. But the captions are often wrong or late. Once, my professor said ‘focus on the pitch,’ but it wrote ‘focus on the beach.’ Everyone laughed, and I laughed too, pretending I understood. Only later did I realise why it was funny. Small errors like that build up—they make you feel like you’re always a step

behind. In class, I try to participate, but it's tiring. The rhythm of conversation moves faster than captions can keep up. I wish Zoom could somehow show tone or emotion along with text. Words alone don't carry that. Sometimes I close my eyes and imagine being in a real classroom again, just hearing and feeling people talk."

Participant 8 – Layla (F, 28, Turkish, IELTS 7.0, High tech user, UX designer)

"What I miss most about in-person work is the transition moments—the small talk before meetings, the jokes after. On Zoom, everything begins and ends too cleanly. I join early sometimes, thinking maybe I can catch those casual chats, but it's just me and a silent screen. When others join, they're half visible, adjusting lighting, muting, unmuting. We exchange awkward smiles. There's no soft landing, just sudden presence. When the meeting ends, it's even stranger—one second we're discussing deadlines, the next, everyone disappears. I often stay on the empty screen for a few seconds, staring at my own reflection, thinking, 'That's it?' It's like social gravity doesn't exist online. You don't drift in or out—you just appear and vanish."

Participant 9 – Daniel (M, 33, Filipino, IELTS 6.5, Advanced tech user, lecturer)

"When students join late, they always apologise, and it breaks the rhythm. But I realise I do the same thing in big faculty meetings. You join mid-discussion, and everyone pauses, glances, and then tries to continue like nothing happened. I usually wait for someone to acknowledge me, but often they don't. It's funny—you're on camera, so you're technically visible, but it still feels like no one sees you. I think that's what Zoom does—it makes presence feel optional. You can be there and not be there. I try to overcompensate by smiling or nodding a lot, but it feels performative, like I'm signalling engagement rather than feeling it. After long meetings, I'm exhausted—not from the content, but from pretending to be 'present.'"

Participant 10 – Mei Hua (F, 41, Chinese, IELTS 6.0, Intermediate tech user, admin officer)

"Leaving a Zoom meeting gracefully is impossible. You wave, say 'bye,' wait for someone to respond, but by the time they do, you're already gone. Other times, no one says anything back, and you're just frozen there, smiling into silence. I used to wait longer, hoping someone would acknowledge me, but now I just click 'Leave Meeting' and close the laptop fast, like ripping off a band-aid. In person, leaving has warmth—you stand up, people say 'see you,' maybe share a quick chat on the way out. Online, it's mechanical. The screen goes black, and you're alone again. It's such a small thing, but it reminds me how fragile online connection is—one click, and everything disappears."

Participant 11 – Carlos (M, 29, Brazilian, IELTS 7.0, High-tech user, research collaborator)

“During one collaboration meeting, my colleague kept gesturing while muted—pointing, circling shapes in the air, even miming equations. None of us noticed because her square was small on the screen. Later she wrote in chat, ‘I was explaining that part!’ We laughed, but inside I felt frustrated for her. In a physical room, body language carries half the conversation. On Zoom, you have to fight to be noticed. I’ve learned to exaggerate reactions—big nods, thumbs-up—just to show engagement. It feels theatrical, like acting rather than discussing. When everyone’s camera is off, I over-interpret silence: is it disagreement, confusion, or just multitasking? Sometimes I wish for a subtle ambient cue—a shimmer around whoever’s attentive. I love how Zoom lets global teams connect, but it also strips the conversation down to the bare minimum: words, lag, and guesses.”

Participant 12 – Aiman (M, 27, Malay, IELTS 6.0, Intermediate tech user, software engineer)

“I always hesitate at the end of meetings. There’s that awkward moment where everyone says ‘Okay... thanks...’ and then nobody leaves first. In the office, someone stands up, chairs scrape, the signal is clear. Online, the cursor hovers over ‘Leave,’ and you’re trying to read who will click first. I sometimes fake a quick ‘Oh, I have another call!’ to justify my exit. Once, I actually stayed two extra minutes pretending to check emails because I didn’t want to look rude. It’s ridiculous how digital politeness works. I miss that shared rhythm of ending together—packing up laptops, walking out chatting. Now it’s each person disappearing alone into their own silence. The efficiency is great, but the humanity feels thinner.”

Participant 13 – Fatima (F, 22, Arabic, IELTS 6.0, Intermediate tech user, university student)

“Sometimes when joining breakout rooms, I get the message ‘Waiting for host to assign you.’ Those few seconds feel endless. I stare at my face on the screen, wondering if they forgot me. When the room finally opens, everyone’s mid-conversation and laughing. I smile and wave, but they barely notice. It’s like entering a circle already formed. Once I even introduced myself three times before someone responded. It’s not anyone’s fault—just timing—but it makes me more cautious. I wish Zoom gave a preview of what’s happening inside, so you can catch the tone before entering. The waiting room feels like an invisible hallway where no one can see you. You’re present, but nowhere.”

Participant 14 – Deepa (F, 34, Tamil, IELTS 6.5, High-tech user, academic staff)

“Teaching through slides on Zoom is like speaking into fog. I can’t read faces, can’t tell if students are following. I keep asking, ‘Can you see this?’ or ‘Does that make sense?’—just fishing for signals. In class, I’d notice someone squint or tilt their head and immediately re-explain. Online, I only notice silence. Once, I shared a complex diagram and talked for ten minutes before realising my screen share had frozen. Nobody said anything—they thought it was their Wi-Fi. I felt foolish but also lonely. The medium removes micro-feedback, so you compensate with over-talking. By the end of each lecture, my voice hurts more from trying to sound alive.”

Participant 15 – Jorge (M, 30, Chilean, IELTS 6.5, Advanced tech user, PhD candidate)

“That 10-second countdown when breakout rooms close always ruins the mood. Everyone suddenly straightens up, smiling nervously. You can’t start a new topic because you’ll be cut off, but you don’t want to just stare. So we fill the gap with small talk: ‘Guess we’re going back now!’ or ‘Nice chatting!’ It’s mechanical, like actors waiting for the curtain to drop. I once had a meaningful discussion that ended mid-sentence when the timer hit zero. I felt robbed of closure. That digital yank reminds me we’re guests of software, not owners of space. Real conversations fade naturally; online, they vanish by code.”

Participant 16 – Siti (F, 27, Malay, IELTS 6.5, High-tech user, HR specialist)

“When someone waves goodbye on Zoom, there’s always lag. You wave back, but they’ve already disappeared. I end up laughing at myself, alone. These little mismatches accumulate—they chip away at sincerity. I once had a farewell meeting for a colleague moving overseas. We all tried to toast on camera, but half the screens froze, audio stuttered, and she said later she couldn’t hear our goodbyes. It broke my heart a bit. Technology connects us but filters out warmth. You start performing affection rather than sharing it. Still, I’m grateful it lets us see faces from around the world—just wish those moments didn’t end so abruptly.”

Participant 17 – Nikhil (M, 32, Indian, IELTS 7.0, Advanced tech user, business analyst)

“Being moved into breakout rooms feels like teleporting without warning. One moment you’re listening; the next, you’re in a new space with unfamiliar names. I need a few seconds to orient—who’s leading, what’s the topic—but by then someone’s already asking me a question. Once I joined mid-debate, and they assumed I was an expert on something I hadn’t heard. I laughed it off but felt lost the entire time. The lack of transition makes me cautious—I hold back until I understand the tone. In-person, you’d walk up, overhear snippets, gauge energy. Here, it’s digital dislocation. Great for efficiency, terrible for rhythm.”

Participant 18 – Lina (F, 24, Korean, IELTS 6.5, Intermediate tech user, design student)

“I always misjudge when to leave meetings. Sometimes I say ‘Bye, everyone!’ and then someone adds, ‘Wait—one more thing!’ So I stay, smiling awkwardly for five extra minutes. Once, I tried leaving quietly, but Zoom showed a notification, and everyone said, ‘Oh, Lina left already?’—like I’d done something wrong. Exiting a digital space shouldn’t be this stressful. In person, you can drift out gradually, exchange looks, wave. Here, it’s binary: here or gone. I’ve started using humour—‘Okay, disappearing now!’—to make it lighter, but deep down it still feels clumsy. Leaving shouldn’t need strategy.”

Participant 19 – Marco (M, 26, Spanish, IELTS 6.5, Advanced tech user, researcher)

“Every time someone joins mid-conversation, it’s like a tiny earthquake. The ding sound, the new face popping in—everyone pauses to greet them, and the flow breaks. It’s polite, but it fragments attention. In one workshop, people kept jumping in and out because of bad connections, and we never regained rhythm. I wish Zoom faded people in more softly, maybe let them observe before appearing. Real-life arrivals are gradual—you sense footsteps, presence builds. Online, it’s a flash. These jolts make long meetings feel disjointed, like reading a book where pages keep shuffling themselves.”

Participant 20 – Rani (F, 37, Indonesian, IELTS 5.5, Intermediate tech user, NGO coordinator)

“Once I joined a meeting late, and the moment my camera turned on, everyone stopped talking. My mic wasn’t working, so I just waved. They waved back politely, but I could tell I’d interrupted. Later, when I left, I didn’t say anything—I just clicked ‘Leave Meeting.’ It felt easier than breaking the flow again. Online spaces don’t allow soft entrances or exits; you’re either invisible or spotlighted. In physical settings, you can slip in quietly, sit, smile, join naturally. On Zoom, every move feels amplified. It makes me anxious, even though I’m comfortable with people in real life. Presence shouldn’t feel like intrusion.”